SOUPS

AKTION / INSTALLATION, OFFENBACH, 2023



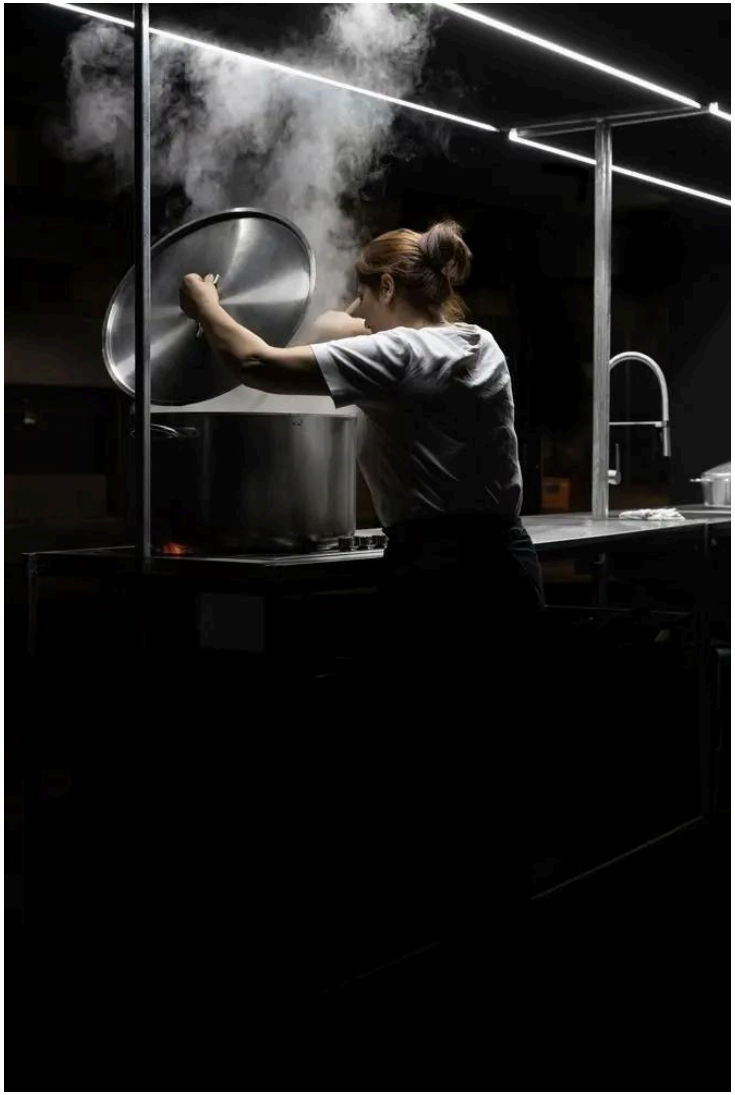
Soups (2023) Offenbach

Soup, a universal dish rooted in many national cuisines, was the inspiration for the participatory art project SOUPS. YRD.Works conceived and realised the project on behalf of the City of Offenbach in the Rathaus-Pavillon, a building in the city centre that was vacant at the time. For the project, the collective created a temporary architecture that served as both kitchen and dining room. The spatial installation consisted of several kitchen elements, a large seating structure made specially for the project, and a big 100-litre soup pot placed at the centre of the room.

The kitchen, made up of four mobile stainless-steel workstations, allowed for professional cooking during the day. In the evenings, the kitchen elements were pushed aside to open the room for eating together. The soup pot at the heart of the installation was staged under a precisely placed spotlight. This was the only source of light in the black-painted room, inevitably drawing attention to the pot as the focal point of the architecture. The installation arranged around the pot allowed all guests to sit together on the furniture, each at the same distance from the pot in the middle of the room.

Over a period of five weeks, the artists invited various actors from Offenbach initiatives and groups to a total of 15 events to cook a soup together according to their personal recipes. The result was 15 soups from the diverse countries (of origin) and cultures of the participants. For each dish, the cooks handed out between 150 and 200 portions free of charge to visitors, which were then eaten together.

Over the course of the action, SOUPS developed into a recurring ritual that foregrounded both the connecting process of cooking together and the shared use of inner-city space. The Rathaus-Pavillon became a social meeting point and a place of exchange. Cooking the soup together in one large pot created a symbolic connection between all participating Offenbach residents. SOUPS was a project that made visible the diversity, but also the unity, of a heterogeneous urban society.



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